UK INTERNATIONAL STUDENT KNOWLEDGE BASE

A practical guide with a focus on students from India

Visa • Study • Work • Money • Accommodation • Healthcare • Safety • Career

Edition: 12 November 2026
Coverage: United Kingdom, with England-specific tenancy and council-tax notes where stated

A plain-English reference for planning, settling in and staying compliant. Always verify live rules with official sources before acting.

How to use this guide

This document is an orientation and knowledge-base resource for Indian citizens studying in the UK. It covers common practical questions from pre-departure through post-study planning. Immigration, tax, housing and healthcare rules can change; your own visa conditions and university guidance take priority.

Important: This is general information, not legal, immigration, tax or financial advice. Do not rely on a summary to make a visa application or take a decision that could affect your immigration status. Check the linked official pages and seek a regulated immigration adviser or qualified professional where needed.

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1. Before leaving India

Choose and verify your institution

- Check that the university or college is a licensed Student sponsor and that the course, campus, mode of study and intake match your offer and Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies (CAS).
- Read the offer, refund policy, tuition-fee schedule, accommodation terms and any placement-year conditions before paying. Keep written receipts and correspondence.
- Speak directly to the university about course structure, attendance expectations, assessment, placement eligibility, academic support and what happens if you defer or withdraw.
- Be cautious with education agents. Do not pay into personal bank accounts or rely on verbal promises about jobs, visas, placements or permanent residence.

Documents and preparation

- Carry your passport, visa/eVisa access details, CAS and university contact details, accommodation address, financial evidence where relevant, academic records and prescriptions/medical letters.
- Keep encrypted digital copies and a separate secure backup. Do not email passport scans or one-time passcodes to unknown people.
- Arrange suitable travel insurance for the journey and first days if appropriate. Check baggage rules for medicines and food; declare restricted items.
- Plan arrival transport and the first few nights. Share your itinerary with someone you trust.

Indian-specific preparation

- Keep your Indian SIM active if it is used for bank OTPs; check international roaming and account recovery before departure.

- Tell your Indian bank that you will be abroad, check card international-use settings and understand fees. Never share UPI PINs, card PINs or OTPs.
- If carrying a substantial amount of cash, check current UK customs declaration rules and Indian foreign-exchange rules before travel.
- The High Commission of India in London publishes student advisories and registration information. Follow its current instructions rather than relying on forwarded messages.

2. Student visa and eVisa

Your permission and conditions

A Student visa is tied to the sponsored course and the conditions granted by the Home Office. Check the digital immigration status in your UK Visas and Immigration (UKVI) account, including the start/end dates and work conditions. The visa is not a general work or business visa.

- Do not travel before the permission start date shown in your immigration status.
- Keep your passport details, email address and phone number current in your UKVI account. Make sure you can access the account when travelling.
- Use the official online service to create or access your eVisa and generate a share code when an employer or landlord needs to check your status. A share code is time-limited; generate a fresh one when required.
- Check that your eVisa details are correct. Report errors through the official UKVI process promptly.
- Do not overstay. Apply for any extension or switch before your current permission expires and follow the relevant route's eligibility requirements.

Dependants

Not every student can bring dependants. Current rules generally restrict new Student-route dependants to certain government-sponsored students and eligible postgraduate research students, including doctoral or research-based higher degrees meeting the rules. Check Appendix Student and the university's international office before making plans.

If something changes

- Contact the university's international student/visa compliance team immediately if you defer, suspend, repeat, change course, change institution, withdraw or stop attending.
- Do not assume that a university approval automatically changes your immigration permission. A new CAS or new visa application may be required.
- Keep copies of Home Office decisions and all university notifications. Ask for advice before leaving the UK while an application is pending.

3. Working while studying

Your exact work permission is determined by your eVisa and the Immigration Rules. For many students on a full-time degree-level course at a higher education provider with a track record of compliance, the usual limit is 20 hours per week during term-time and full-time work outside term-time. Other course/provider types can have lower limits or no permission to work.

Do not assume that every student has a 20-hour allowance. Confirm your own condition and your university's official term dates.

What counts

- The limit normally applies across all jobs combined, not separately to each employer. Keep an accurate weekly record of hours, including work for multiple employers.
- Check how your university defines term-time, vacation and dissertation periods. Do not rely on a manager's interpretation.

- An authorised work placement that is an integral and assessed part of the course may be permitted under separate rules. Obtain written confirmation from the university and make sure the placement meets the course and visa requirements.

Activities that are prohibited or risky on a Student visa

- Self-employment and engaging in business activity are generally prohibited. This can include freelancing, operating a business, working as a contractor, or providing services on a self-employed basis.
- Do not assume that registering a company, selling through a website or marketplace, earning only a small amount, calling revenue a donation, or operating a business overseas makes the activity permissible.
- Professional sportsperson/sports-coach work and filling a permanent full-time vacancy are also restricted under Student-route conditions.
- Unpaid work is not automatically exempt. A genuine permitted volunteering role differs from unpaid work that is actually employment or a commercial placement.

Practical job checks

- Before accepting a role, ask the employer whether it is employment or self-employment, how hours are recorded, and whether the job duties are compatible with your visa.
- Give the employer a valid right-to-work share code. Keep your contract, payslips, rota and timesheets.
- Never work extra hours off the books. If a manager asks you to breach your visa conditions, contact your university's international student team.

Pay and workplace rights

You should receive the applicable National Minimum Wage/National Living Wage where the law covers your work. Check the current rates on GOV.UK. You may also have rights relating to payslips, holiday pay, rest breaks, discrimination and workplace safety. Employment status matters: employee, worker and genuinely self-employed people can have different rights.

4. Study, attendance and placements

- Attend required teaching, supervision, assessments and engagement activities. Respond to university attendance and engagement messages.
- Understand the academic calendar, submission deadlines, resit rules, progression requirements and academic-integrity policy.
- Tell the university promptly if illness, bereavement, financial difficulty or another serious issue affects attendance or performance.
- For a placement year, confirm in writing the placement dates, minimum hours, whether it is paid/unpaid, assessment requirements, supervision and how it is recorded by the university.
- Do not treat a placement as permission for unrelated side work or business activity. Your visa conditions still apply.
- Keep evidence of placement applications, offer letters, learning objectives, reviews and final assessment.

Academic support

Use the university library, careers service, writing and study-skills support, counselling/wellbeing service, disability support where relevant, and students' union advice. Ask for help early; do not wait until a deadline or visa issue becomes urgent.

5. Money, banking and tax

Budgeting

Build a realistic monthly budget covering rent, bills, food, transport, phone, study materials, clothing, travel and emergencies. London costs can be materially higher than many other UK cities. Do not plan to fund tuition or essential

living costs solely through part-time work.

- Keep an emergency reserve and track spending weekly. Compare the total cost of a room, not just advertised rent: bills, council tax exposure, travel and deposits matter.
- Use regulated banks/payment providers. Check transfer fees and exchange rates before sending money from India.
- Never let another person use your bank account to receive or move money. This can expose you to money-mule and fraud risks.

National Insurance and payroll

- You need a National Insurance number to make sure your tax and National Insurance contributions are recorded correctly. You can usually start work before it arrives if you can prove your right to work.
- Give your employer accurate starter information and check your payslips. Keep your P45/P60 and payroll records.
- Income tax is generally handled through PAYE for employees. If you think too much tax has been deducted, check your HMRC Personal Tax Account and follow HMRC guidance.
- National Insurance contributions depend on earnings and the applicable thresholds. Do not assume every payslip deduction is income tax.

Public funds and financial support

Student-route permission normally includes a 'no access to public funds' condition. Do not claim benefits or public funds unless you have checked the exact benefit and your immigration position with a qualified adviser. University hardship funds, scholarships and charitable support are different from public funds, but eligibility and visa implications should be checked.

Indian tax and remittances

If you maintain financial or tax connections with India, residency and tax treatment can depend on days present, income source and other facts. UK tax residence can also matter. Do not assume that money transferred from India is automatically taxable or automatically tax-free. Keep records and seek cross-border tax advice for material amounts or business income.

6. Accommodation and renting

Before paying

- View the property in person or by a trusted live video tour. Verify the landlord/agent and the address. Avoid paying a deposit or rent to an unrelated personal account before verifying the arrangement.
- Read the written tenancy/licence agreement. Confirm who lives there, room dimensions, rent due dates, bills, deposit, notice period, house rules and repair responsibilities.
- Get a receipt for every payment. Photograph the room and inventory at move-in and report existing damage in writing.
- In England, most tenancy deposits for assured tenancies must be protected in a government-approved tenancy deposit scheme. Ask for the prescribed information and scheme details.
- For shared houses, check whether the property requires an HMO licence and whether the landlord has the required permission. Ask the local council if unsure.

Right to rent and council tax

In England, most private renters must prove their right to rent. If you have an eVisa, you normally use the Home Office online service to generate a right-to-rent share code. The rules differ across the UK nations.

Full-time students may qualify for a council-tax exemption, but the result depends on the course and everyone living in the property. If you share with non-students, liability may arise for the household or landlord depending on the arrangement. Ask the local council; do not assume every housemate is exempt.

Living safely in shared accommodation

- Check smoke alarms, locks, heating, hot water, ventilation and fire exits. Do not block escape routes.
- Agree cleaning, guests, noise, shared food, bills and notice arrangements with housemates.
- Report urgent hazards or serious disrepair in writing and keep copies. Contact the council's housing team or a tenant-advice service if the landlord does not respond.

7. Healthcare and wellbeing

Many students who pay the Immigration Health Surcharge as part of their visa application can use NHS services on broadly the same basis as people ordinarily resident, subject to the applicable rules and charges. Some services, including prescriptions, dental treatment and eye care in England, may still involve charges or eligibility rules.

- Register with a local GP soon after arrival. A GP is usually the first point of contact for non-emergency health concerns.
- Use NHS 111 for urgent medical advice when it is not a life-threatening emergency. Call 999 or go to A&E; for a life-threatening emergency.
- Keep prescriptions and medical records accessible. Check rules before bringing medicines from India; some medicines have controlled-drug restrictions.
- Look after sleep, nutrition, exercise and social connection. University wellbeing and counselling services can help.

Emergency: 999 for police, fire or ambulance when there is immediate danger or a serious emergency. For non-emergency police matters, use 101 in England and Wales.

8. Daily life, safety and emergencies

Transport and identity

- Use official transport apps/websites and check student discounts. Carry the correct ticket or pass; penalty fares can be expensive.
- If driving, check that your licence and insurance allow you to drive in the UK. Rules depend on the licence country, residence and vehicle; do not assume an Indian licence can be used indefinitely.
- Keep your passport secure. You generally do not need to carry it every day; use a safe alternative ID where accepted.

Scams and discrimination

- Be alert to fake landlords, job offers, visa agents, parcel/customs texts, bank calls and people claiming to be police or Home Office officials.
- Government agencies and banks will not ask you to reveal your password, PIN or one-time passcode. Do not transfer money to a 'safe account'.
- Keep evidence of harassment, hate crime, wage theft or discrimination. Report immediate danger to 999; seek university, police, Citizens Advice or specialist support as appropriate.

Useful emergency habits

- Save your university's 24-hour security number, accommodation emergency contact, GP details, landlord/agent contact and a trusted local contact.
- Tell a trusted person if you are travelling late or meeting an unfamiliar recruiter/landlord. Meet in public and do not hand over original documents unnecessarily.
- If your passport is lost or stolen, report it to the police where appropriate and contact the Indian passport/consular service for replacement guidance.

9. Career planning and post-study routes

Build employability while studying

- Use the university careers service, employer events, alumni network, professional associations and placement office.
- Prepare a UK-style CV tailored to each role. Focus on measurable outcomes, relevant skills and evidence; avoid unnecessary personal information such as date of birth, religion or passport number.
- Build a portfolio of projects, presentations, case studies or code samples where relevant. Ask permission before publishing employer or client work.
- Keep a record of applications, interviews, networking contacts and feedback. Check job adverts for sponsorship eligibility if you may need a work visa.

Graduate visa — critical 2027 change

As at 12 November 2026, the official GOV.UK guidance states that a Graduate visa lasts **2 years** for applications made on or before 31 December 2026, and **18 months** for applications made on or after 1 January 2027. A PhD/other doctoral qualification has a 3-year period. The Graduate route is not extendable, though switching to another eligible route may be possible.

You must be in the UK, hold Student/Tier 4 permission when applying, have successfully completed an eligible course, and have your education provider notify the Home Office of successful completion. You do not need to wait for the graduation ceremony or certificate if the provider has made the required notification. Apply before your Student permission expires.

A Graduate visa normally permits work, including self-employment, subject to its conditions. It does not itself guarantee a job, sponsorship or settlement. Plan early for a possible Skilled Worker or other route and check the current salary, occupation, sponsor and eligibility rules at the time.

Other routes

Potential routes may include Skilled Worker, Innovator Founder or other work/family routes, depending on eligibility. Each has distinct requirements. Do not rely on informal claims that a business idea, low revenue, unpaid founder role or company registration automatically qualifies. Get regulated immigration advice before taking action.

Avoid last-minute planning

- Check your course completion reporting timeline with the university and ask when it expects to notify the Home Office.
- Set calendar reminders well before visa expiry. Confirm the correct application window, fees, Immigration Health Surcharge and evidence requirements on GOV.UK.
- If applying in-country, understand the effect of a pending application on travel. Leaving the Common Travel Area can have serious consequences for some pending applications; verify the current rules before travelling.

10. Indian-student-specific checklist

Before departure

- Confirm CAS, visa grant and course start date.
- Set up UKVI account/eVisa access and check passport details.
- Arrange first accommodation and airport transfer.
- Tell Indian bank about overseas use; preserve access to OTPs.
- Carry essential prescriptions and supporting medical information.
- Save university international office and High Commission contacts.

First two weeks in the UK

- Complete university enrolment and any identity/attendance checks.
- Register with a GP and learn local urgent-care options.
- Open a UK bank account if eligible and arrange safe bill payments.

- Get a UK mobile number while retaining access to essential Indian accounts.
- Check eVisa and create share codes only when needed.
- Read tenancy terms, document room condition and understand bills.
- Learn the exact term dates and your personal work conditions.

Every month

- Track attendance, deadlines, rent, bills and spending.
- Keep payslips, rota and work-hour records.
- Check immigration email/account messages and keep contact details current.
- Review job/placement progress and seek help early.
- Avoid cash-in-hand work, unauthorised self-employment and suspicious money transfers.

Before course completion

- Get written confirmation of the expected course completion date.
- Ask when the university will report successful completion to the Home Office.
- Check Graduate route duration based on the date you will actually apply.
- Compare eligible sponsored jobs and other routes well before visa expiry.
- Do not let your Student permission expire while waiting to make a decision.

11. Official links and support

Use these primary sources for the live rules. Pages may be updated after this PDF's edition date; always check the page itself before acting.

- **UK Student visa overview**
https://www.gov.uk/student-visa

- **Immigration Rules — Appendix Student**
https://www.gov.uk/guidance/immigration-rules/immigration-rules-appendix-student

- **UKCISA — Student work**
https://www.ukcisa.org.uk/student-advice/working/student-work/

- **UKCISA — Working in the UK (tax and NI)**
https://www.ukcisa.org.uk/student-advice/working/working-in-the-uk/

- **Graduate visa overview**
https://www.gov.uk/graduate-visa

- **Graduate visa — course studied**
https://www.gov.uk/graduate-visa/course-you-studied

- **UKVI eVisa and share codes**
https://www.gov.uk/evisa

- **Set up a UKVI account**
https://www.gov.uk/evisa/set-up-ukvi-account

- **Right to rent in England**
https://www.gov.uk/prove-right-to-rent/overview

- **Student renting guidance**
https://www.gov.uk/private-renting/student-tenancies

- **UKCISA — Council tax**
https://www.ukcisa.org.uk/student-advice/life-in-the-uk/council-tax/

- **NHS — Healthcare for overseas visitors**
https://www.nhs.uk/nhs-services/visiting-or-moving-to-england/

- **High Commission of India, London — student advisory**
https://www.hcilondon.gov.in/page/dont/

• **GOV.UK — Coming to the UK from India**
https://www.gov.uk/world/coming-to-the-uk-india

• **GOV.UK — National Insurance number**
https://www.gov.uk/apply-national-insurance-number

• **GOV.UK — National Minimum Wage rates**
https://www.gov.uk/national-minimum-wage-rates

• **GOV.UK — Find an immigration adviser**
https://www.gov.uk/find-an-immigration-adviser

Document note: Prepared 12 November 2026. The guide is designed as a starting knowledge base, not a substitute for checking current law, your eVisa conditions, university policy or advice from an appropriately regulated professional.